

Sports **FOOTBALL**

By Elora Sen



To swear by a football club is something that millions do all over the world. A club born and raised in Meghalaya's sleepy laidback capital Shillong is scripting another chapter of the sport's unique grassroots story and bringing about a revolution of sorts in Indian football. Not many people in India's vast land had heard about a team called Shillong Lajong FC. Until the day they put the brakes on the mighty Churchill Brothers in the semi-final of the Federation Cup a day away from New Year's eve. Yet it has already turned out to be a New Year for what Shillong calls "Our Own". It is what the word Lajong means in the local Khasi language.

For decades now, the seven sister states of the North-east and Sikkim traditionally have produced great footballers for India. The lack of a proper club in the region though forced them to move to other states to satisfy professional aspirations. Until in 1983, when the idea of Lajong took root. During a match in Shillong, two prominent citizens, P.D. Sawyan and Kitdor Syiem, watched the local team get thrashed but heard fans cheer every move of the visitors. A local club that could hold its



The Red **DEVILS**

A football club from the tiny hill state of Meghalaya keeps the North-east's flag flying high and enjoys a memorable season at the highest level of Indian football

own against teams from other states would, they believed, raise quite a stir. Born in 1983, it took the club more than a quarter of the century to become the first club from the North-east to qualify for the top ladder of Indian football—the I-League—in the 2009-10 season.

Lajong's fate took a turn for the better when Sawyan's son, Larsing M. Sawyan, 34, took over its management in 2000. Larsing has grown up loving the team that had been close to his fa-

ther's heart, played for it when 15 and knew that it could give people of the area a sense of identity. After Churchill was beaten he says, "I got calls from all over the North-east congratulating us. It was almost as if Lajong has given them a reason to believe that it can be done, and can be done here."

When the team played East Bengal in the final, several hundreds of fans caught buses and trains to travel to Guwahati to root for the team. The

team lost to the mighty Kolkatans, but after their impressive run, the players could hold their head high.

Though several of the club's players had in the past been selected for the junior football teams, it was only in 2006 that the team qualified for the second division of the National Football League. In April 2009, Lajong were in a different league altogether. Having made it to the top tier of national football scene, the team is now